



Coupon Chronicles

For thirty-two years I went shopping with my coupon box in tow without ever seeing another consumer with either a coupon box or binder. Not once. I spotted small coupon wallets that fit in a purse or envelopes of coupons, but never a box or binder. By early 2011, I was beginning to see women with coupon binders everywhere I went. All of a sudden, couponing was hot. It was as if couponing was a totally new concept, and yet coupons had been around for over 125 years.

The coupon as a form of marketing and promotion was introduced in the late 1880s, when a voucher for a free glass of Coca-Cola was distributed under the ownership of John Pemberton, who invented the product in 1886. Pemberton gradually sold portions of his business to partners, and then Asa G. Candler, a brilliant Atlanta businessman, achieved sole ownership of the company in 1891. Candler expanded on the innovative idea of giving out a complimentary Coca-Cola. His handwritten coupons offered a free glass of the beverage that was selling only nine glasses a day in its first year. Distributed on the streets of Atlanta, then through the mail and company salesmen, by 1913 an estimated 8.5 million free drink coupons had been redeemed. It seems a daring move—a company giving away its product—but it proved to be an effective one.